Was that always there?

Look for about five seconds, then look away. Note three things that caught your attention. Do not turn the page yet. No timer or score is required.



I noticed:

Look again. Same picture.

Look for an upside-down U: a semicircular arch open at the bottom. Find where it repeats. This is the exact same illustration as page 1.

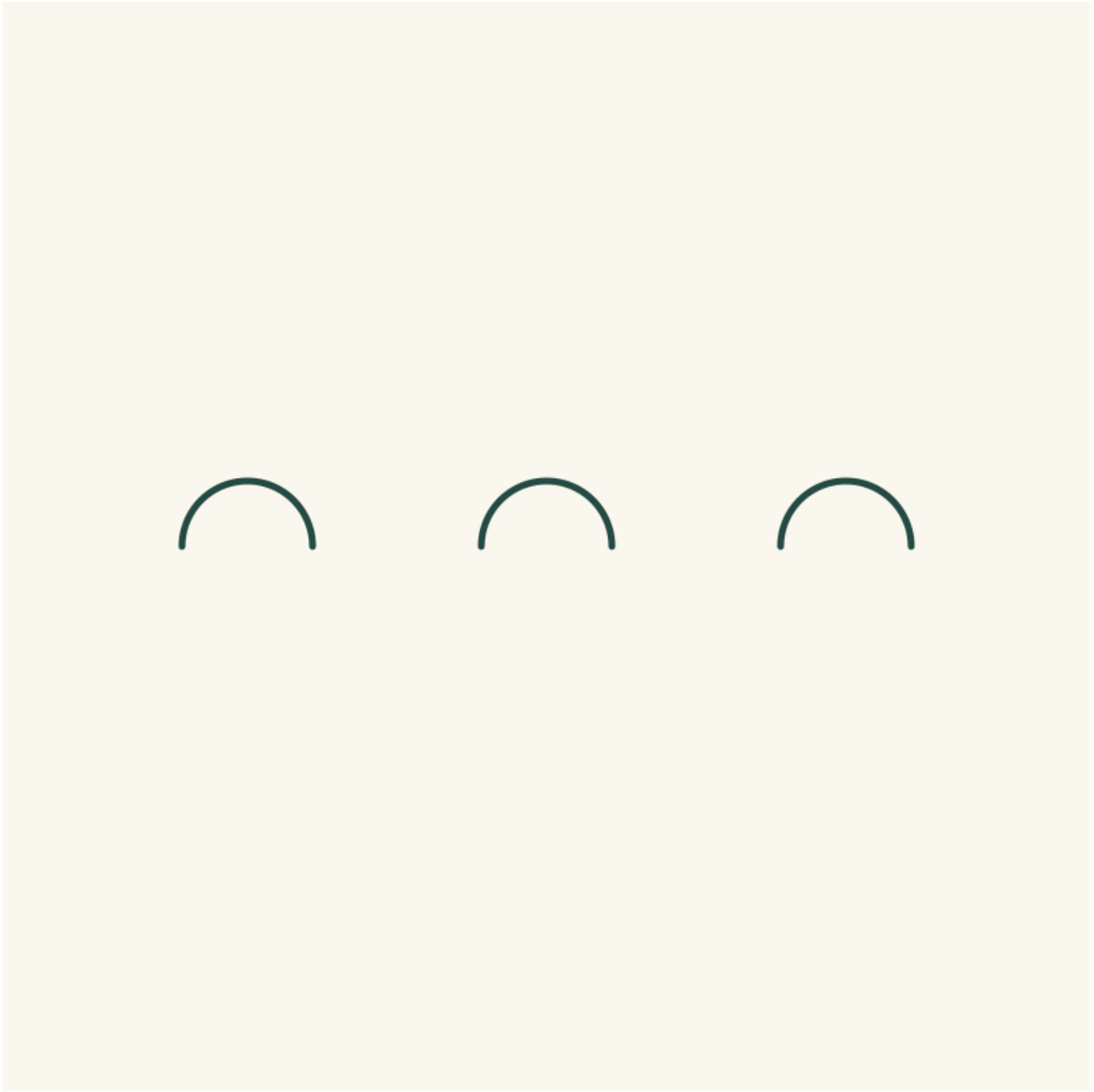


Did the picture change, or did what you noticed change? A second look also gives you more time and practice; no particular reaction is required.

Text-first alternative: read the same list twice. First recall what stood out, then look for things used when eating: brick, cloud, cup, tree, bread, door, plate, window, book, spoon, pond, bowl.

One motif. Many possibilities.

Keep all three arches visible and in the same relative positions. Rotate or uniformly resize the whole starter only. Imagine three meanings; add two clues to develop one. Rough sketches and written ideas



My first idea / another possibility:

What else might I be overlooking?

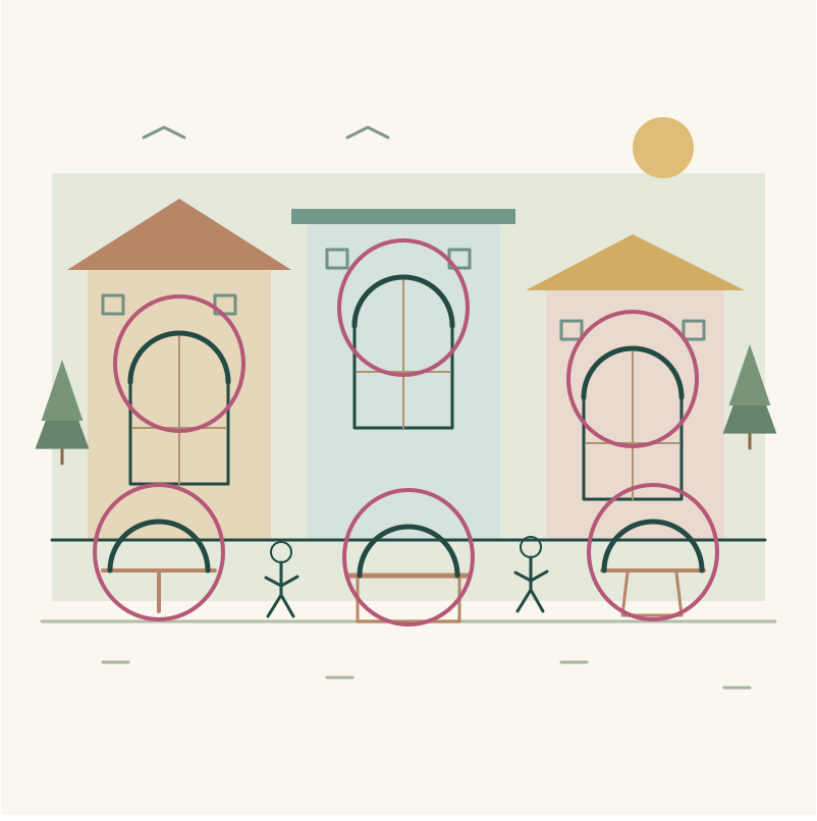
Reflect, then explore

Thinking behind the challenge

This activity explores selective attention and is inspired by the frequency illusion: after noticing something, you may spot it more often and feel it has become more common. Noticing more does not prove that the actual frequency increased.

This is an illustration, not a psychological test. If you noticed the arches immediately, choose a different detail and look again.

The six repeated arches are the three window tops, the lower-left canopy, the lower-centre stall top and the lower-right mushroom-like form. The rings below are explanatory additions.



Try your own interpretations before viewing our examples online. Drawing needs no account; sign in only if you choose to submit for review.

Source: Arnold Zwicky, The Shadow knows (22 April 2018). arnoldzwicky.org/2018/04/22/the-shadow-knows/